



Expecting Miracles

Government services could benefit immensely by using open source software. Many of their programs and processes need an urgent overhaul. And there are many enthusiasts in the open source community who would love to help.

I am at an age when I can adjust my time, location and tasks to minimise frustrations that I cannot manage. Once a year, reality bites. I have to prove that I am alive in order to get a minimal pension. I postpone it for months beyond the due date; but there are many other old people waiting and struggling to get their pensions.

As I wait and contemplate, it strikes me as yet another example of misunderstanding or misusing information technologies.

I recently had an argument with a relative only to realise that his perspective was that computers are always right. He seemed to think computers are a miraculous solution to our problems. He found it hard to believe that someone could feed false data into a system, including biometrics, and create virtual citizens who are non-existent except on the system.

As an example, the people who work at the EPFO (Employees' Provident Fund Organisation) assume that it is easy for individuals to have their finger or retina scanned, get an OTP, and prove their identity in a few seconds.

The first issue I have with this is that it ignores the time and cost required for a person to visit the centre and then, the waiting time! I recall a mainframe ad that stated, "What is the point of getting an answer in a second, if you can't get to the question for a year?"

The second point is that it costs the EPFO a substantial sum of money to verify the identity of each pensioner once a year, stop the pension of each person who has not submitted a life certificate and then pay the unpaid pension amounts, when he does submit a certificate.

The third issue is: what happens when a person is immobilised by age or illness?

What could be a better way

Pension is given to a person who is alive. So, in principle, pensioners should prove they are alive each month! A year is just a convenient period chosen during the manual processing days. There is no point in 'improving' it by reducing paperwork and introducing Aadhaar-identification.

When a death certificate is issued, the information is available and can be shared with the EPFO. The EPFO can update the pensioner's records appropriately. The need for a life certificate disappears.

Any system can be gamed. So, there are bound to be cases when a fraud has been committed. The people currently processing each pensioner's life certificate should instead focus on fraud detection. They need to handle only exceptions and abnormal cases.

The EPFO has been used merely as an illustration. Each one of us can find instances of processes which have been 'improved' by information technology without reflecting on the necessity of those processes in the connected environment.

Sadly, the processes that do not differentiate between a potential misuse of ₹ 1 and ₹ 1 billion are more common than one would have thought. Reality is even sadder. For one rupee, the person has to manage the process oneself. In the case of a billion rupees, the person will most likely have agents who will manage the process on his behalf!

Public services software should be open

I recently came upon a public sector site that had an error — the starting date was later than the current date. I was trying to get a report from April 1, 2018 to January 31, 2019! It seemed obvious that the programmer was ignoring the year. It may be that the comparison is assuming that the date is in 'ddmmyy' format, whereas it is being entered in 'ddmmyyyy' format. I am sure I or many others would be happy to submit a patch and fix the issue if only the code was available. This can reduce the cost of the public services while improving the quality of the services provided.

More significantly, since we are providing information to the government, we would like to be sure that it is not being misused. The classic example that comes to mind is of the banking software in which a programmer had transferred a fraction of a cent on each rounding-off, to his own account!

How can we as citizens be sure that the programs written and managed by a third party do not leak certain information to related parties? For example, it would be comforting to know that the program that registers the births and deaths shares the data with only sites which should get that data for the convenience of the citizens, and not with anyone else.

Last but not least, it would offer an opportunity to people, like those who are retired but would like to use their experience to improve the public services from the comfort of their homes, at their own convenience, without having to rejoin the rat-race :) 

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